

Delegation from Lithuania
Position Paper for the General Assembly Third Committee
National Model United Nations, New York, April 2023

The topics before the General Assembly Third Committee are Healthy Ageing and Age-Friendly Sustainable Development, and Safeguarding the Human Rights of Persons Displaced by Climate Change. Lithuania considers progress on both issues essential to sustainable development and welcomes their inclusion in the Committee's agenda.

I. Healthy Ageing and Age-Friendly Sustainable Development

The United Nations defines ageism as stereotyping, prejudice and discrimination based on age. As the Global Report on Ageism states, ageism arises when age is used to categorise and divide people in ways that lead to harm, disadvantage and injustice, and that erode solidarity across generations.

Ageism damages health and well-being and remains a major barrier to effective policies for healthy ageing. Member States of the World Health Organization recognised this in the Global Strategy and Plan of Action on Ageing and Health and in the Decade of Healthy Ageing 2021–2030, which mandated WHO to work with partners on a global campaign against ageism.

Lithuania has consistently supported age equality and the objectives of the 2030 Agenda. The 2030 Agenda sets out a universal plan of action to achieve sustainable development in a balanced manner and to realise the human rights of all people. Its commitment to leave no one behind requires that the Sustainable Development Goals be met for all segments of society, at all ages, with particular attention to the most vulnerable, including older persons.

The scale of the demographic shift is well documented. Between 2017 and 2030, the target date of the SDGs, the number of persons aged 60 and over is projected to grow by 46 per cent, from 962 million to 1.4 billion, outnumbering both young people and children under the age of ten. This increase will be fastest in the developing world. Preparing for an ageing population therefore cuts across poverty eradication, good health, gender equality, economic growth and decent work, reduced inequalities and sustainable cities.

Poverty is a direct threat to the well-being of older persons, which makes SDG 1 central to monitoring the ageing-related dimensions of the 2030 Agenda. In its Voluntary National Reviews of 2016, 2017 and 2018, Lithuania reported challenges in social services and poverty reduction, identified population ageing as a significant challenge for its social policy, and set the sustainability of the pension system as a national priority.

Population ageing also reflects genuine achievements in human development, including improved health, greater longevity and lower mortality, as recognised in the Programme of Action of the International Conference on Population and Development. At the same time, it places rising pressure on public health systems to meet growing demand for age-appropriate care, including long-term care and technologies for the prevention, detection and treatment of disease, as set out in the WHO World Report on Ageing and Health (Geneva, 2015). In response, Lithuania has increased the availability of primary healthcare providers.

Ageing populations present opportunities as well as pressures, particularly through the active participation of older persons in the labour market. Lithuania, together with other Member States, underscores the need for targeted measures that enable older workers to remain in employment.

Lithuania recognises that these challenges are not unique to any one country and that joint action is required. The delegation therefore recommends that the Committee:

- (a) encourage Member States to report age-disaggregated data in their Voluntary National Reviews, so that progress towards the Goals can be measured across all age groups;
- (b) establish a standing mechanism for the exchange of best practices on long-term care, pension sustainability and the prevention of age-based discrimination;
- (c) support the WHO-led global campaign against ageism and encourage Member States to align national awareness measures with it;
- (d) promote the participation of older persons in the labour market through flexible working arrangements and access to lifelong learning; and
- (e) ensure that older persons are engaged directly in the planning, implementation and monitoring of the Goals, through consultation processes, stakeholder mechanisms and national workshops.

II. Safeguarding the Human Rights of Persons Displaced by Climate Change

The Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre defines persons displaced by climate change as persons or groups of persons who, predominantly for reasons related to sudden or gradual adverse effects of climate change, are obliged to leave their homes or places of habitual residence, either temporarily or permanently, and who move within their country or across an international border.

Lithuania endorses the Platform on Disaster Displacement, which identifies disaster displacement as one of the greatest humanitarian challenges of the twenty-first century. Every year millions of people are forced from their homes by floods, tropical storms, droughts, glacial melt, earthquakes and other hazards. Most find refuge within their own countries; some must cross borders. Scientific evidence indicates that climate change will increase displacement in the years ahead, both internally and across international borders.

The Global Report on Internal Displacement 2022 records that conflict, violence and disasters triggered 38 million internal displacements across 141 countries and territories in 2021, the second-highest annual figure of the decade after the record set in 2020. Conflict and violence alone accounted for 14.4 million movements, an increase of nearly 50 per cent on the previous year. In Europe and Central Asia, disasters triggered 276,000 internal displacements, driven largely by wildfires in the Mediterranean, storms and floods in western and central Europe, and a volcanic eruption in the Canary Islands.

Lithuania has participated in the Nansen Initiative, the State-led consultation process launched in 2012 to build consensus on a protection agenda for people displaced across borders by disasters and the effects of climate change. Through paragraph 14(f) of the Cancún Agreements adopted at COP16 in December 2010, States recognised climate-induced migration, displacement and planned relocation as an adaptation challenge and undertook to deepen their understanding and cooperation on it. Lithuania has also joined the Global Compact on Refugees, which provides a framework for more predictable and equitable responsibility-sharing and affirms that durable solutions are not possible without international cooperation.

Lithuania recalls draft resolution A/73/L.105, which affirms that all persons, including those displaced by the effects of climate change, have the right to freedom of movement and residence and must be protected from arbitrary displacement. It further recalls Human Rights

Council resolution 35/20 of 22 June 2017 on the urgency of protecting the human rights of migrants and persons displaced across international borders in the context of the adverse effects of climate change, including those from small island developing States and least developed countries. Lithuania recognises the particular vulnerability of displaced women and children to discrimination, sexual and physical abuse, violence and exploitation, and stresses the importance of preventing and responding to sexual and gender-based violence against displaced children.

Lithuania emphasises that States bear the primary responsibility to protect and assist internally displaced persons within their territories and to address the root causes of displacement, in appropriate cooperation with the international community. Climate change is a global problem and requires an international response. The delegation therefore recommends that the Committee:

- (a) build on the Nansen Protection Agenda and the work of the Platform on Disaster Displacement, applying and strengthening existing frameworks rather than negotiating a competing instrument;
- (b) support standardised national data collection on disaster displacement, drawing on the methodology of the Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre, so that responses rest on comparable evidence;
- (c) ensure that protection measures are gender-responsive and address the specific risks faced by displaced women and children, in line with Human Rights Council resolution 35/20;
- (d) reaffirm the primary responsibility of States for internally displaced persons, while strengthening responsibility-sharing under the Global Compact on Refugees for situations that cross borders; and
- (e) integrate displacement risk into national adaptation planning under paragraph 14(f) of the Cancún Agreements, so that displacement is anticipated rather than addressed only after it occurs.